Both, in their own ways, have encouraged a greater sense of collectivism. It was also inevitable that such a significant transformation in the relative weight, influence and behaviour of players should lead to a re-imagining of the arena itself. The irony is that those who are projected as taking the lead are actually coming to terms with a scenario that the fortunes of others have helped create.

THE CONSEQUENCES OF ACT EAST

There is more than adequate evidence of how integrated economic and cultural activities have been between the Indian and the Pacific oceans in history. By its very nature, the maritime domain supersedes artificial barriers and manmade lines. Whether it is trade or faith, mobility or practices, monuments or relationships, we know that the energies of its community traversed the waters over the ages with great comfort.

Assigning labels and restricting activities is a relatively modern phenomenon. In this particular case, the sharp differentiation within the Indo-Pacific was very much the result of the 1945 outcomes. In fact, it has a specific American signature to it that is highlighted by the milestones of its preoccupations in the Far East. Among them are the Second World War itself, the revolution in China, the Korean War, the revival of Japan and the Vietnam War.

As a result, it was quickly forgotten that much of what happened in that theatre was actually driven by forces residing in the Indian Ocean. To that extent, there is again a similarity to the Europe of the previous era. The interests of one great power distort the entire landscape and create concepts for its convenience. But here, too, the wheel of history has started to turn, and the old normal is reasserting itself.

The Indo-Pacific debate has, on occasion, been marked by charges of Cold War thinking. In fact, the truth is the very opposite. That is not surprising given that such rhetoric comes from the very quarters who seek to freeze the advantages of 1945. The Indo-Pacific suggests integration and plurality; its denial means division and dominance. And criticism is really meant to advance classic Cold War goals of constraining freedom of choice and exerting pressure to conform. In fact, to see the Indo-Pacific in binary terms when the interests of many are involved is a dead giveaway. The Indian Ocean may have been relegated to being a strategic backwater for